



CUBA is suffering under a U.S. oil embargo. Above, children play atop an *almendrón* in central Havana. NATALIA FAVRE For The Times

Talks between U.S. and Iran are in doubt

Further negotiations may be on hold after the Navy seizes an Iranian-flagged ship.

By MICHELLE L. PRICE, SAMY MAGDY AND SAM METZ

WASHINGTON — The United States said it forcibly seized an Iranian-flagged cargo ship that tried to get around a naval blockade near the Strait of Hormuz on Sunday, the first such interception since the blockade of Iranian ports began last week.

The news threw into question President Trump's earlier announcement that U.S. negotiators would head to Pakistan on Monday for another round of talks with Iran. A fragile ceasefire is set to expire by Wednesday, and Washington and Tehran remain in a standoff over the strait.

Trump on social media said a U.S. Navy guided missile destroyer in the Gulf of Oman warned the ship, the Toussa, to stop and then "stopped them right in their tracks by blowing a hole in the engineroom." U.S. Marines had custody of the U.S.-sanctioned vessel and were "seeing what's on board!"

There was no immediate Iran comment. The U.S. Central Command said the destroyer had issued "repeated warnings over a six-hour period."

There was also no comment from Iranian officials on Trump's announcement of the talks.

However, Iranian state media, without citing any one beyond unnamed sources, issued brief reports suggesting that talks would not happen.

Minutes after the ship [See Iran, A8]

COLUMN ONE

Optimism fades away amid Cuba's collapse

Historic 2016 opening is swallowed by despair

By KATE LINTHICUM REPORTING FROM HAVANA

A decade ago this spring, President Obama stepped off Air Force One at José Martí International Airport — the first time a U.S. leader had touched ground in Cuba since Fidel Castro's communist revolution.

More than half a century of Cold War hostilities were thawing. The U.S. had relaxed travel restrictions to the island, and Cuba had partially opened its economy to the private sector. Tourists were flocking in as a new class of Cuban entre-

preneurs renovated crumbling buildings into restaurants, art galleries and hotels.

One bright afternoon, Obama took in a baseball game with then-President Raúl Castro, the leaders of longtime enemy nations chatting behind home plate. A few days later the Rolling Stones played a free concert — their first in a country that once banned Western rock. Afterward, thousands of giddy fans thronged the malecón, Havana's seaside promenade, laughing and drinking rum.

I covered Obama's visit for The Times, and remember the thrill in the soft Caribbean air. Cubans were hopeful.

"For the first time in my life, my [See Cuba, A8]



MODELS are photographed in Mariel in 2016 as Cuba opened its economy. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

Farmworkers face more ICE-related threats by bosses

Many stay silent about labor issues, fearing that complaints could get them deported.

By MELISSA GOMEZ

In many years on dairy farms, the worker often labored for 10 hours with no breaks.

Sometimes, he said, a

boss asked him to clean milk tanks using harsh chemicals without protective gear. He was electrically shocked when he stepped into a puddle created by a broken water pump, he said.

At his latest job in Kings County, he stayed silent, fearing he could lose his job.

Last summer, at the height of federal immigration raids in California, the boss issued a warning, according to the worker: If any-

one tried to take legal action against him, he'd make sure they ended up in Tijuana.

For the dairy worker, an undocumented immigrant from Mexico in his mid-50s who requested anonymity to speak about the incident, this felt like the final straw. After more than two decades working on dairy farms, most recently earning about \$1,800 every 15 days, he packed up his things and quit.

"What if they sent someone after me, or they wanted to get rid of me all of a sudden?" he said in a video interview from a farmworker advocacy group's office shortly after leaving his job. "I couldn't bear living there anymore."

Amid President Trump's mass deportation campaign, immigration-related threats from supervisors in the fields are on the rise, farmworkers and advocates

say.

Farmworkers who turned to advocacy groups for help spoke to The Times about their experiences but did not want to be identified for fear of retribution from their employers and the federal government. They described instances in which bosses threatened to call Immigration and Customs Enforcement on them, sometimes because they [See Farmworkers, A6]

Defying critics, California keeps driving business

Despite notable exits, many more firms are moving in or starting, including 'unicorns.'

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

After aerospace startup Space Kinetic was spun out of UC Berkeley in 2022, the company moved to New Mexico and its famous Los Alamos National Laboratory.

One of the founders had a fellowship there to further develop the firm's cutting-edge technology: a craft that would propel smaller satellites through space electro-mechanically rather than by burning rocket fuel.

Space Kinetic still has a facility in New Mexico, but it's expanding rapidly in its new headquarters and manufacturing space — in El Segundo, where it moved last year.

"It came down to the talent density. There's a number of folks who have expertise and the disciplines that we need to hire for," co-founder Ryan Sullivan said. "That paired with the fact

that there's already a kind of well-established deep-tech startup ecosystem."

Space Kinetic's decision is not surprising for a new generation of entrepreneurs who are building on the L.A. region's rich aerospace and defense heritage, following in the path of Elon Musk's SpaceX.

Hypersonic aircraft company Hermeus recently announced that it also was relocating its headquarters to El Segundo from Atlanta, while two Colorado aerospace companies, True Anomaly and Voyager Technologies, opened large plants in Long Beach.

Southern California aerospace startups have doubled down on the region too, opening larger local headquarters as they grow, including space station builder Vast in Long Beach and drone maker Flight-Wave Aerospace in Torrance.

The decisions by these companies to open or expand headquarters, design or manufacturing spaces in California run counter to a narrative that has gained national traction — that the state is bad for business and [See Startups, A7]

State will move water with the sun

By HAYLEY SMITH

LEBEC, Calif. — At the bottom of the San Joaquin Valley, a low-slung Mid-century building tucked into the green-gold hillside is the beating heart of California's impressive water delivery system.

For more than five decades, the Edmonston Pumping Plant has lifted water nearly 2,000 feet up the towering Tehachapi Mountains, connecting water from Northern California to 27 million people in the southern part of the state.

The plant houses 14 rumbling pumps in two football-field-sized wings and is one of the most powerful water lifting systems in the world. But it can need more than 800 megawatts of electricity to run, making it among the largest single power users in the state.

Now the equation is

changing. On a recent weekday morning, dozens of state officials and energy industry representatives gathered at Tejon Ranch, just across the road from Edmonston, to celebrate a sparkling new solar plant that will help power the pumps. The 105-megawatt Pastoria Solar Project from Calpine, part of Constellation Energy Corp., represents the largest renewable energy project contracted by the California Department of Water Resources and is a major step in its plan to fully decarbonize operations by 2035, consistent with state law.

"Most Californians — the equivalent of 1 in 12 Americans — get water from the State Water Project," said Karla Nemeth, director of the Department of Water Resources. "To make that system carbon neutral by 2035, we need efforts like the Pastoria Solar Project. [See Solar, A6]

Push for wildlife coexistence

Uproar over a bear's euthanization spurs calls to help animals and humans live side by side. CALIFORNIA, B1

Honorees salute power of writing

The authors recognized at the L.A. Times Book Prizes ceremony spoke of hope and resistance. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 73/56. B6



JACK DEMPSEY Associated Press

KINGS DROP GAME 1

Avalanche right wing Logan O'Connor scores on Kings goalie Anton Forsberg during Colorado's 2-1 victory in the best-of-seven series. SPORTS, D1

Venice resident fights bar noise. Some are calling him a 'Karen'

By FEDOR ZARKHIN

David Feige is tired. Tired of the noise blasting from bars near his multi-story Venice Beach home. Tired of the people dealing drugs, urinating and fighting in the alley. Tired of asking restaurant owners, repeatedly, simply to follow the law.

But now, his fight to get several establishments on one iconic block to tone it down has turned personal — and frightening — after

"wanted" posters with Feige's photo suddenly appeared around town, dubbing him "The Venice Karen."

"Who builds a multi-million dollar house right behind Hinanos (Est. 1962) and then calls the police 30 times in one day to complain about the noise?" the signs read. "Last seen manically calling 911 from a brand-new Mansion."

The posters escalated a neighborhood dispute into a public attack that Feige, who is 60 and the newly

elected neighborhood council president, says has added untold stress to his life. He is now dealing with threats on social media, including someone implying his house should be set on fire, according to screenshots he provided.

"It's painful and upsetting," Feige said in an emailed response to questions about the posters. "What surprised me about it was how many people just took it as true."

The Venice Karen post- [See Venice, A9]

